

From Division to Reconnection

Urban Expressways and the Neighborhoods They Changed in Rochester, Buffalo, and Syracuse

Mid-century highway building promised speed, access, and metropolitan growth. In many American cities, however, the new expressways also became instruments of physical separation. They cut through established neighborhoods, displaced residents and businesses, severed local street networks, and reinforced patterns of segregation and disinvestment that had already been shaped by discriminatory housing and lending policies.

Few figures symbolize that era more powerfully than Robert Moses. Moses did not design Rochester's Inner Loop, Buffalo's Kensington Expressway, or Syracuse's I-81 viaduct. His projects in New York City nevertheless helped define a planning philosophy that elevated automobile mobility and regional traffic flow over the continuity of existing urban neighborhoods. The Cross Bronx Expressway is the most prominent example: New York City planning documents describe it as a project that split densely populated communities, demolished thousands of homes, displaced residents and businesses, and left a physical divide that endured for generations.[1]

That philosophy was not confined to New York City. Federal highway investment, urban renewal, suburbanization, redlining, and local redevelopment policies converged in cities across the country. Upstate New York offers three particularly revealing examples. Rochester, Buffalo, and Syracuse each built major highway infrastructure through or beside established neighborhoods during the same broad era. Today, all three are attempting, in different ways, to repair those divisions. Their experiences raise a question that reaches beyond transportation engineering: when a city removes or redesigns infrastructure that contributed to decades of separation and disinvestment, what does meaningful reconnection require?

The Highway Era: Mobility at a Human Cost

Postwar transportation policy treated congestion and downtown accessibility as problems that could be solved by moving vehicles more efficiently. Expressways promised suburban commuters direct access to central business districts while linking cities to rapidly expanding regional highway networks. But the land needed for these projects was not empty. Routes passed through neighborhoods where people lived, operated businesses, worshiped, attended school, and relied on local social networks.

The neighborhoods most vulnerable to clearance were frequently those that had already been weakened by public and private discrimination. Redlining limited access to conventional mortgage credit. Racial covenants and discriminatory real estate practices restricted where Black families could live. Urban renewal programs labeled many older neighborhoods 'blighted,' making them targets for clearance. Highway construction then added a physical layer to those existing inequalities. Concrete walls, ramps, trenches, and elevated structures transformed social and economic divisions into barriers embedded in the city itself.

This distinction matters. Expressways did not create every form of segregation or disinvestment that affected these neighborhoods. But they often intensified existing inequities, removed homes and businesses, redirected investment, and made connections between neighborhoods more difficult. The history of Rochester, Buffalo, and Syracuse demonstrates how those decisions continue to shape contemporary planning.

Rochester: From the Inner Loop's 'Moat' to a Restored Street Grid

Rochester's Inner Loop was built in the late 1950s and early 1960s as the city's population was declining from its 1950 peak and suburban development was accelerating. Its purpose was to distribute traffic through and around downtown. The physical cost was substantial: City records indicate that 149 parcels were razed, while Rochester's broader urban-renewal era eliminated or disrupted low-income and Black neighborhoods, including Baden-Ormond and Clarissa Street. City historical materials explicitly acknowledge that construction of the Inner Loop between 1952 and 1965 demolished and divided neighborhoods.[2]

The result was sometimes described as a 'moat' around downtown. Before the loop, the downtown street network blended more directly into surrounding residential areas. The sunken expressway interrupted that continuity, prioritized through traffic, and created a barrier between the center city and adjacent neighborhoods.[3]

Rochester is now one of the nation's most visible examples of highway removal as a redevelopment strategy. The Inner Loop East project, completed in 2017, filled approximately two-thirds of a mile of the sunken expressway and replaced it with an at-grade complete street. The project reclaimed about six acres for redevelopment, improved pedestrian and bicycle connections, and reconnected the East End with downtown. By early 2023, more than 500 housing units had been developed in the former expressway area, with the City reporting that more than 60 percent were for residents earning below area median income.[4]

The next phase is more ambitious. The Inner Loop North Transformation is intended to replace the remaining 1.5-mile northern segment with a pedestrian- and bicycle-friendly street grid, reconnect downtown with nearby neighborhoods, the Public Market and High Falls, create green space, and reclaim approximately 22 acres for redevelopment and public space. The final Mobility and Development Strategy was completed in December 2025, preliminary engineering is underway, and construction is anticipated to begin in 2027. Highland Planning served as the public-engagement consultant for the Mobility and Development Strategy.[5]

The Rochester experience illustrates both the promise and the challenge of reconnection. Removing the barrier can restore streets and create land, but equitable redevelopment requires deliberate choices about housing affordability, public space, local business opportunities, transportation access, and who benefits from the increase in land value created by public investment. The City's current process places continued public engagement at the center of design, an important contrast with an era when residents living in the path of major infrastructure had far less influence over the outcome.

Buffalo: Reimagining the Kensington Expressway and the Lost Humboldt Parkway

Buffalo's Kensington Expressway tells a particularly vivid story because the highway replaced a celebrated piece of urban landscape. Humboldt Parkway was part of the park and parkway system designed by Frederick Law Olmsted and Calvert Vaux. It featured a broad, tree-lined median and connected what is now Martin Luther King, Jr. Park with Delaware Park, linking local streets, neighborhoods, institutions, and recreational destinations.[6]

The construction of Route 33 transformed that landscape into a depressed expressway through Buffalo's East Side. The change did more than replace trees with traffic lanes. It altered neighborhood connections and placed a major transportation corridor through communities that would experience decades of disinvestment. The contrast between the original parkway and the expressway is a reminder that transportation infrastructure is never merely functional; its design determines whether streets and corridors connect community life or separate it.

Buffalo's effort to address the Kensington legacy is currently evolving. New York State previously advanced a project centered on creating a tunnel over a portion of the expressway and restoring green space above it. That proposal was challenged in court. In April 2025, NYSDOT announced that it would not appeal the court decision and would instead restart public engagement while maintaining its commitment to a major transportation project intended to reconnect the East Buffalo community.[7]

The State subsequently launched 'Queen City Forward,' a new community-driven process to reimagine the Kensington corridor. NYSDOT opened a dedicated project hub in late 2025 and continued a series of listening sessions into 2026, inviting residents to help shape the next major investment along Route 33.[8] Unlike Rochester's completed Inner Loop East removal or Syracuse's selected Community Grid, Buffalo's final remedy remains unsettled. That uncertainty is itself an important planning lesson: repairing past infrastructure decisions requires not only design expertise and funding, but also public legitimacy. The form of the solution matters, and so does the process through which the community determines what 'reconnection' should mean.

Syracuse: I-81, the 15th Ward, and the Community Grid

In Syracuse, the relationship between highway construction and racial segregation is especially direct. The historic 15th Ward became home to many Black residents and other groups who faced barriers to housing elsewhere in the city. The City of Syracuse describes the neighborhood as having been constrained by redlining, racial covenants, and other discriminatory practices before urban renewal and the construction of I-81 devastated the community. More than 500 businesses were destroyed and thousands of residents were displaced.[9]

The elevated viaduct became a lasting boundary between downtown and neighborhoods to the east and south. Residents who remained near the highway also lived with the environmental and economic consequences of proximity to a major transportation corridor. As the aging viaduct approached the end of its useful life, the question facing

Syracuse was not simply how to replace a highway structure, but whether the city should reproduce the same physical division for another generation.

New York State selected the Community Grid alternative. The project will remove approximately 1.4 miles of elevated highway and replace the viaduct's local function with an at-grade street network designed to reconnect neighborhoods, improve pedestrian and bicycle mobility, modernize infrastructure, and provide additional ways to reach downtown. Phase One began in 2023 with work on the interstate system surrounding the city. In July 2026, NYSDOT announced the beginning of Phase Two, focused on dismantling the viaduct and building the infrastructure needed for the Community Grid.[10]

Syracuse is also treating the highway project as a neighborhood-development opportunity. The City's Connecting the Historic 15th Ward initiative and Community Grid Vision Plan address land use, housing, economic development, public spaces, and bicycle and pedestrian accommodations. The East Adams Neighborhood Transformation, developed with the Syracuse Housing Authority and community partners, is intended to use the removal of the viaduct as an opportunity to reinvest in the area and respond to the historic destruction of the 15th Ward.[9][11]

This broader approach is important. A transportation project can remove a physical barrier, but the neighborhoods affected by that barrier also need housing stability, economic opportunity, public amenities, environmental improvements, and access to the land and investment created by redevelopment. Syracuse's challenge is therefore not only to build a street grid, but to ensure that the new grid supports a community rather than simply creating new real estate opportunities around it.

Three Cities, Three Paths Toward Repair

Rochester, Buffalo, and Syracuse are not pursuing identical solutions. Rochester has demonstrated the potential of full expressway removal through Inner Loop East and is moving toward removal and grid restoration on Inner Loop North. Syracuse has committed to removing its elevated I-81 viaduct and replacing its local function with a Community Grid. Buffalo has returned to community engagement to reconsider how best to reconnect neighborhoods divided by the Kensington Expressway.

The differences are instructive. Highway remediation is not a single design technique. In some locations, removal and restoration of the street grid may be feasible. In others, planners may consider caps, tunnels, boulevards, redesigned interchanges, green space, or combinations of approaches. The appropriate physical solution depends on transportation needs, neighborhood context, environmental conditions, cost, land use, and community priorities.

Yet the three cities share a deeper objective: converting infrastructure that separated neighborhoods into investments that create connections. That means measuring success by more than vehicle travel time or acres reclaimed. A successful project should also ask whether residents can safely walk and bicycle across former barriers; whether new housing is affordable to a range of incomes; whether existing residents and businesses can remain and benefit; whether environmental burdens are reduced; whether public spaces serve surrounding communities; and whether people historically excluded from major planning decisions have meaningful influence over what is built.

Repairing More Than Infrastructure

The central lesson of the urban-expressway era is not that planners should stop building infrastructure. It is that infrastructure decisions are also community-development decisions. A roadway can determine which parcels become valuable, which businesses receive traffic, which neighborhoods are accessible, where pollution is concentrated, and whether residents experience the city as a connected network or a collection of isolated districts.

The same is true when a highway is removed. Reconnection can create extraordinary opportunities, but it can also generate new development pressure. If land values rise while long-time residents are displaced, a project may repair the physical street grid without repairing the inequities associated with the original infrastructure. Equitable reconnection therefore requires coordination among transportation planning, land-use policy, affordable housing, economic development, environmental justice, public-space design, and anti-displacement strategies.

Meaningful public engagement is equally important. Engagement should begin early enough to influence fundamental decisions, continue as designs become more detailed, and include residents who may not participate in traditional public meetings. Neighborhood organizations, renters, homeowners, small businesses, youth, older adults, people with disabilities, transit riders, cyclists, pedestrians, institutions, and historically marginalized communities may experience the same corridor differently. Those differences are planning information, not obstacles to planning.

The history of Rochester, Buffalo, and Syracuse also demonstrates why planners must understand the cumulative effect of public policy. Highway construction cannot be separated from the housing, lending, urban-renewal, and suburban-development policies that shaped the same neighborhoods. Likewise, today's solutions should not be isolated transportation projects. Reconnection is most meaningful when infrastructure investment is coordinated with the long-term social and economic goals of the communities it is intended to serve.

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Cities inherit the consequences of decisions made generations earlier. Rochester's Inner Loop, Buffalo's Kensington Expressway, and Syracuse's I-81 viaduct were products of an era that placed extraordinary confidence in large-scale infrastructure as a solution to urban problems. Those projects improved regional automobile movement, but they also imposed lasting costs on neighborhoods that had limited power to resist them.

Today, the three cities have an opportunity to demonstrate a different model of planning. Rochester is converting expressway land back into streets, housing, development sites, and green space. Syracuse is replacing an elevated viaduct with a community grid while pursuing a broader neighborhood transformation. Buffalo has reopened the conversation about the future of the Kensington corridor and is asking the community to help define the next approach.

The measure of success will not simply be whether concrete is removed, covered, or rebuilt. It will be whether the people and neighborhoods that lived with these barriers share in the benefits of their transformation. The most important evolution in planning may therefore be less about the physical form of the roadway than about who has a voice in shaping the city. Moving from division to reconnection requires planners to understand history, acknowledge the consequences of past decisions, and design future investments with communities rather than around them.

Sources

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